

Teachers and Dragons

by Alec Sloman

The Core Design

This manual adapts the playbook logic of Powered by the Apocalypse games to teaching practice.

The core principle is fiction-first classroom action: if you actually do the thing in the room, the move triggers. A move is not a slogan, a technique label, or a decorative activity. It is a precise teaching action under real conditions, with consequences.

The dice are a design grammar. You can use them literally for training, coaching, simulation, or reflection, or treat the result bands as a way to describe how well a teaching action landed.

When a move says the room makes a move, that does not mean students are being blamed. It means classroom reality answers back: attention shifts, time pressure increases, a misconception surfaces, trust frays, a routine fails, the task proves mismatched, or the next decision becomes harder.

The Teaching Stats

Stat	Use it when the move depends on...
Clarity	explanation, sequencing, modelling, cognitive load
Presence	attention, pacing, voice, emotional command of the room
Rapport	trust, participation, dignity, peer interaction
Diagnosis	noticing, evidence, misconceptions, adaptive judgement
Rigor	precision, challenge, evidence, disciplinary standards
Momentum	routines, transitions, practice flow, classroom systems

Presence

Presence is a teacher’s command of attention and authority in the classroom. Internally, a high-Presence teacher stays confident and poised; externally, they use posture, gaze, or pauses to focus the class.

Rigor

Rigor is the teacher’s insistence on accuracy, evidence, and intellectual challenge. Internally, a rigorous teacher remains intellectually sharp; externally, they press students for justification

and proof.

Momentum

Momentum is a teacher's sustained drive and pacing. Internally, a teacher with Momentum stays upbeat and persistent; externally, they keep the lesson moving and recover quickly from setbacks.

Clarity

Clarity is the teacher's precision in presenting ideas. Internally, a clear-thinking teacher organizes content tightly; externally, they explain with simple examples and structure.

Rapport

Rapport is the teacher-student emotional connection. Internally, a rapport-strong teacher is empathetic and positive; externally, they create trust and belonging through kindness and encouragement.

Diagnosis

Diagnosis is the teacher's ongoing assessment of student understanding. Internally, a diagnostic teacher is reflective and curious; externally, they continuously check learning and adjust.

Making a Move

When the fiction triggers a particular move, roll 2d6 and add your relevant stat.

- On a **10+**, the move lands cleanly. You get the intended teaching effect and often gain a bonus, option, or follow-up advantage.
- On a **7-9**, the move works, but with a cost, compromise, partial effect, or demanding choice.
- On a **miss**, the room makes a move. Something real changes, and you must respond to the new classroom state.

When a move gives you **hold**, keep that many points and spend them one-for-one on the listed options during the same lesson sequence.

When a move gives you **+1 forward**, add +1 to the next directly related move.

The Room Makes a Move

Roll when a teacher move misses and classroom reality answers back. The move should:

- reveal pressure,
- expose reality,
- force adaptation,

- or change the state of the classroom encounter.

The room is not your enemy. But it always answers back.

d20	The Room Makes a Move
1	Attention Fractures — Side conversations spread faster than you can redirect them. The next move that depends on whole-class focus takes -1 forward unless you Reset the Room.
2	The Wrong Idea Sticks — A misconception becomes the most memorable thing in the lesson. Students begin repeating it confidently.
3	Dead Air — Participation collapses into silence, avoidance, or passive compliance. Someone must safely restart the thinking.
4	The Pace Breaks — Transition time expands unexpectedly. Materials, movement, or confusion consume valuable minutes.
5	One Student Shuts Down — A learner withdraws publicly or quietly after feeling exposed, confused, or overwhelmed.
6	The Confident Few Take Over — Discussion narrows to the same voices. Others disengage into observation mode.
7	Procedures Eclipse Learning — Students become focused on “doing the task correctly” rather than understanding the concept.
8	The Energy Turns — Irritation, restlessness, or low-level emotional friction spreads through the room.
9	The Task Was Misjudged — The work is clearly too difficult, too easy, or cognitively mismatched. Students respond accordingly.
10	Guessing Replaces Thinking — Students begin hunting for answers, cues, or teacher approval instead of reasoning.
11	The Room Splits — Part of the class is ready to move on while another part is lost. Any next move risks leaving someone behind.
12	Momentum Drains Away — The lesson continues, but the sense of direction weakens. Students comply without investment.
13	A Hidden Misconception Surfaces — A student reveals a deeper conceptual confusion beneath the current task.
14	The Social Risk Rises — Students become more cautious about speaking publicly. Incorrect answers now carry visible tension.
15	Noise Floods the Edges — Off-task behaviours multiply around the perimeter of the room while instruction continues at the centre.

d20	The Room Makes a Move
16	The Example Becomes the Rule — Students imitate the surface features of a model without understanding the transferable principle.
17	The Lesson Narrows — A tangent, debate, or behavioural issue begins consuming the instructional purpose.
18	Students Wait You Out — The room learns that hesitation, silence, or confusion will eventually make you rescue them.
19	The Cognitive Load Spikes — Too many instructions, terms, or decisions arrive at once. Students begin dropping parts of the process.
20	Reality Escalates — Choose two: a behavioural issue intensifies, time pressure sharpens, materials fail, emotions spill over, or the core objective becomes unstable.

Universal Teacher Moves

These are available to every teacher regardless of style, subject, or philosophy. They are the foundational actions of classroom cognition management.

Attention Moves

Used to direct and stabilize attention.

Reset the Room

When you pause instruction because attention has fractured and deliberately re-establish the shared focus, roll +**Presence**.

- On a **10+**, the room returns to you cleanly. Choose three:
 - the reset is brief;
 - no student is publicly shamed;
 - the next instruction is heard by almost everyone;
 - you identify what caused the fracture.
- On a **7-9**, attention returns, but choose one cost:
 - you lose more time than planned;
 - the reset feels heavier than you wanted;
 - one pocket of the room remains only superficially with you.
- On a **miss**, the reset becomes part of the disruption. The room makes a move: irritation rises, attention fragments again, or the underlying cause demands direct attention.

Signal Importance

When you mark information as essential through emphasis, pacing, repetition, placement, or visual anchoring, roll +**Clarity**.

- On a **10+**, students can tell what matters and why. Choose two:
 - they can repeat the core idea in usable language;
 - they connect it to the task ahead;
 - they distinguish it from surrounding detail;
 - take +1 forward to a related Check for Understanding or Guided Practice.
- On a **7-9**, the signal lands, but unevenly. Choose one:
 - some students remember the phrase but not the meaning;
 - the emphasis interrupts the lesson flow;
 - you must restate it later in a different form.
- On a **miss**, the wrong thing becomes salient, or the signal sounds like noise. The room makes a move.

Tighten Transition

When you move the class from one activity, grouping, resource, or mode of attention to another, roll +**Momentum**.

- On a **10+**, the transition preserves momentum. Choose three:
 - students know what to do first;
 - materials or spaces are ready;
 - talk volume stays appropriate;
 - the first task begins quickly.
- On a **7-9**, the transition happens, but choose one cost:
 - you must repeat the instruction;
 - a few students lag or drift;
 - setup eats into the next phase.
- On a **miss**, the transition becomes the lesson. The room makes a move: confusion, off-task talk, missing materials, or lost pace.

Scan the Room

When you rapidly read the room for engagement, confusion, participation, or emotional temperature, roll +**Diagnosis**.

- On a **10+**, hold 3.
- On a **7-9**, hold 1.
- On a **miss**, you misread the room or notice too late. The room makes a move.

Spend hold one-for-one to ask and answer honestly:

- Who is ready to move on?
- Who is silently lost?
- Where is attention thinning?
- Which misconception is forming?
- What should I adjust next?

Participation Moves

Cold Call

When you invite a named student to contribute without waiting for volunteers, roll +**Rapport**.

- On a **10+**, the call raises participation without damaging trust. Choose two:
 - the student answers or attempts productively;
 - the room treats the answer as thinking, not performance;
 - you gain useful evidence about understanding;
 - take +1 forward to Bounce or Probe.
- On a **7-9**, the student participates, but choose one:
 - they need a scaffold before answering;
 - the answer reveals more uncertainty than expected;
 - the social risk in the room rises.
- On a **miss**, the move feels like exposure or the answer collapses. Repair dignity before pressing further.

Turn and Talk

When you prompt students to discuss with a peer before whole-class response, roll +**Rapport**.

- On a **10+**, hold 3.
- On a **7-9**, hold 1, and choose whether to accept shallow talk or spend extra time deepening it.
- On a **miss**, talk disperses, pairs stall, or the prompt was not clear enough. The room makes a move.

Spend hold one-for-one to:

- surface a student idea worth sharing;
- identify a misconception safely;
- invite a quieter student into the whole-class conversation;
- build consensus before moving on;
- take +1 forward to Bounce, Check for Understanding, or Consensus Build.

Wait Time

When you ask a question and deliberately hold silence so students can think, roll +**Presence**.

- On a **10+**, the silence becomes productive. Choose two:
 - more students prepare an answer;
 - the first response improves in quality;
 - a student revises before speaking;
 - take +1 forward to Press for Precision or Probe.
- On a **7-9**, the wait helps, but choose one:
 - some students drift;
 - you must restate the question;
 - the room needs a sentence stem, cue, or narrower choice.
- On a **miss**, silence reads as confusion, avoidance, or loss of control. The room makes a move.

Bounce

When you redirect one student's response to another student or group for uptake, extension, or challenge, roll +**Rapport**.

- On a **10+**, the second response genuinely builds the conversation. Choose two:
 - they add evidence;
 - they refine the idea;
 - they disagree respectfully;
 - the original speaker remains included.
- On a **7-9**, the bounce works, but choose one:
 - the second student needs a scaffold;
 - the contribution repeats rather than extends;
 - you must protect the tone of the exchange.
- On a **miss**, the exchange stalls, turns performative, or feels like a trap. Return to the purpose of the question.

Explanation Moves

Model Thinking

When you externalize expert cognition through a think-aloud, roll +**Clarity**.

- On a **10+**, students see the invisible process. Choose three:
 - you name the decision points;
 - you show what you notice;
 - you expose a possible mistake and correct it;
 - students can imitate the next step.
- On a **7-9**, the model helps, but choose one:
 - it is slightly too long;
 - students copy the surface without grasping the reasoning;
 - you must pause to label the strategy more explicitly.
- On a **miss**, the model obscures the thinking or makes the process look magical. The room makes a move.

Worked Example

When you demonstrate a complete process step by step before students attempt it, roll +**Clarity**.

- On a **10+**, the example becomes a usable path. Choose two:
 - each step has a visible reason;
 - students can predict the next step;
 - you mark common error points;
 - take +1 forward to Guided Practice.
- On a **7-9**, the example works, but choose one:
 - one step remains under-explained;
 - the example is too easy or too hard;
 - students will need a second example before independence.
- On a **miss**, students can reproduce the example only by copying, or the process seems more confusing than before.

Chunk Information

When you break complex material into manageable units, roll +**Clarity**.

- On a **10+**, the load drops and the structure becomes visible. Choose two:

- students can name the chunks;
- each chunk has a purpose;
- links between chunks are clear;
- take +1 forward to Signal Importance or Retrieval Practice.
- On a **7-9**, the chunks help, but choose one:
 - the boundaries feel artificial;
 - one chunk is still overloaded;
 - students miss how the pieces reconnect.
- On a **miss**, simplification distorts the concept or fragments the lesson into disconnected parts.

Rephrase

When you restate an idea with altered wording, analogy, representation, or structure because the first version did not land, roll **+Diagnosis**.

- On a **10+**, the new version opens access. Choose two:
 - students show recognition;
 - the misconception weakens;
 - the idea becomes easier to apply;
 - take +1 forward to Check for Understanding.
- On a **7-9**, the rephrase helps some students, but choose one:
 - it introduces a new ambiguity;
 - it works only for part of the class;
 - you must return to the original academic language.
- On a **miss**, the rephrase creates a second confusion or lowers the rigor too far.

Diagnostic Moves

Check for Understanding

When you rapidly gather evidence of comprehension before deciding what to do next, roll **+Diagnosis**.

- On a **10+**, hold 3.
- On a **7-9**, hold 1, and the evidence is noisy or incomplete.
- On a **miss**, your check gives false confidence or muddies the picture. The room makes a move.

Spend hold one-for-one to:

- identify who is secure;
- identify who needs immediate support;
- reveal a misconception;
- decide whether to advance, pause, or reteach;
- take +1 forward to Cognitive Pivot, Guided Practice, or Exit Ticket.

Hinge Question

When you ask a decisive conceptual question whose answer determines whether the lesson can progress, roll +**Diagnosis**.

- On a **10+**, the response pattern gives a clear instructional decision. Choose one:
 - move on with confidence;
 - reteach precisely;
 - split the class into targeted paths.
- On a **7-9**, the question gives useful but imperfect evidence. Choose one:
 - ask a follow-up and lose time;
 - move on but mark a risk;
 - reteach broadly rather than precisely.
- On a **miss**, the hinge question was not diagnostic enough, or students answer for the wrong reason. The room makes a move.

Probe

When you push beyond a shallow, incomplete, or lucky answer to uncover the thinking underneath, roll +**Rigor**.

- On a **10+**, the probe reveals reasoning. Choose two:
 - the student clarifies their logic;
 - the class sees what counts as understanding;
 - a misconception becomes usable;
 - take +1 forward to Ask for Evidence or Press for Precision.
- On a **7-9**, you get more thinking, but choose one:
 - the student needs more support than expected;
 - the class grows impatient;
 - the answer becomes longer but not clearer.

- On a **miss**, the probe feels like interrogation or drives the student into guessing. Repair the exchange.

Ask for Evidence

When you require a student to justify, support, or ground a claim, roll +**Rigor**.

- On a **10+**, evidence enters the conversation cleanly. Choose two:
 - the claim strengthens or changes;
 - students see the standard for support;
 - weak evidence is exposed without humiliation;
 - take +1 forward to Source Interrogation or Press for Precision.
- On a **7-9**, evidence appears, but choose one:
 - it is partial;
 - it is relevant but not sufficient;
 - you must model how to connect evidence to claim.
- On a **miss**, the demand for evidence shuts the exchange down or turns into answer-hunting.

Practice Moves

Guided Practice

When you have students first attempt a skill or concept while you provide active support, roll +**Clarity**.

- On a **10+**, practice begins within the right zone of difficulty. Choose three:
 - most students know the first step;
 - errors are visible early;
 - your scaffold supports without doing the thinking;
 - you know when to release more responsibility.
- On a **7-9**, students can start, but choose one:
 - the scaffold is too heavy;
 - the task exposes an unexpected gap;
 - several students require immediate redirection.
- On a **miss**, practice begins before understanding is ready, or the support masks the lack of understanding.

Confer

When you give targeted individual or small-group feedback during work time, roll +**Rapport**.

- On a **10+**, hold 3.
- On a **7-9**, hold 1, and the conference costs more time or attention than planned.
- On a **miss**, the feedback misses the real need, overwhelms the student, or pulls you away from a wider problem.

Spend hold one-for-one to:

- name the next actionable step;
- preserve student ownership;
- uncover a hidden misconception;
- connect the feedback to the success criteria;
- take +1 forward to Targeted Drill or Goal Ladder.

Retrieval Practice

When you require students to recall prior learning from memory, roll +**Momentum**.

- On a **10+**, retrieval strengthens access. Choose two:
 - the prompt targets important knowledge;
 - students retrieve before you reteach;
 - errors become useful evidence;
 - take +1 forward to Signal Importance or Trace the Idea.
- On a **7-9**, retrieval works, but choose one:
 - confidence varies widely;
 - students need cues sooner than expected;
 - the task checks recall but not transfer.
- On a **miss**, the practice becomes a guessing game, or students confuse retrieval with being tested and judged.

Exit Ticket

When you collect end-of-lesson evidence to decide what the next lesson requires, roll +**Diagnosis**.

- On a **10+**, the exit ticket gives a clean next move. Choose two:
 - you can group responses meaningfully;
 - the prompt distinguishes error types;

- the evidence connects to the lesson objective;
- take +1 forward to your next planning move.
- On a **7-9**, the evidence helps, but choose one:
 - the prompt was too broad;
 - responses show performance but not reasoning;
 - you must sample rather than read everything.
- On a **miss**, the ticket measures the wrong thing, arrives too late to matter, or hides the real learning state.

Archetypes

The archetypes are not personalities. They are preferred tactical doctrines. A teacher can multiclass.

The Instructor

Clarity, structure, explicitness.

Passive Bonus

When an Instructor move lands on a **10+**, students experience reduced cognitive load during the next related explanation or practice sequence.

Signature Moves

Direct Instruction

When you introduce novel content through concise, sequenced explanation with controlled pacing, roll +**Clarity**.

- On a **10+**, students leave the explanation knowing what matters, how it works, and what to try next. Take +1 forward to Guided Practice.
- On a **7-9**, the instruction is clear enough to begin, but choose one:
 - one step needs a second model;
 - students can follow but not yet explain;
 - you must slow down and sacrifice planned content.
- On a **miss**, the explanation outruns the learners, overloads them, or hides the key decision point.

Worked Sequence

When you chain multiple worked examples from simple to complex, roll +**Clarity**.

- On a **10+**, the sequence reveals the pattern beneath the examples. Choose three:
 - each example adds one meaningful variation;
 - students anticipate the next move;
 - misconceptions are pre-empted;
 - the final example prepares students for independent practice.
- On a **7-9**, the sequence helps, but choose one:
 - the jump between examples is too large;
 - students notice procedure but not principle;
 - you need one more example than planned.
- On a **miss**, the examples become a list to memorize rather than a structure to understand.

Guided Release

When you gradually remove scaffolds over successive tasks, roll +**Diagnosis**.

- On a **10+**, responsibility transfers at the right pace. Choose two:
 - students notice what support has been removed;
 - errors increase just enough to teach from;
 - confidence remains intact;
 - take +1 forward to Targeted Drill or Exit Ticket.
- On a **7-9**, the release works unevenly. Choose one:
 - some students still need the scaffold;
 - some students are ready for more challenge;
 - you must pause to clarify expectations.
- On a **miss**, you release too early, hold too long, or mistake compliance for independence.

Precision Check

When you use rapid diagnostic questioning to target likely misconceptions, roll +**Diagnosis**.

- On a **10+**, the check exposes the state of understanding quickly. Choose two:
 - the questions distinguish similar errors;
 - students stay mentally active;
 - you know what to reteach;

- take +1 forward to Cognitive Pivot.
- On a **7-9**, you get useful data, but choose one:
 - pace pressures accuracy;
 - only confident students reveal themselves;
 - one misconception remains hidden.
- On a **miss**, the check turns into recitation, guessing, or a false signal of mastery.

The Socratic

Questioning, reasoning, intellectual tension.

Passive Bonus

When a Socratic move lands on a **10+**, student responses gain depth over the next exchange.

Signature Moves

Press for Precision

When you refuse vague language and require a clearer term, claim, distinction, or explanation, roll +**Rigor**.

- On a **10+**, the student's thinking sharpens. Choose two:
 - the class hears the difference between vague and precise;
 - the student revises without losing face;
 - the improved wording becomes reusable;
 - take +1 forward to Ask for Evidence.
- On a **7-9**, precision improves, but choose one:
 - you must supply a choice of terms;
 - the exchange slows the room;
 - the student sounds precise without fully understanding.
- On a **miss**, the demand feels pedantic, punitive, or confusing. The room makes a move.

Productive Silence

When you intentionally extend wait time beyond comfort after a demanding question, roll +**Presence**.

- On a **10+**, the silence becomes thinking space. Choose two:
 - a stronger answer emerges;

- more students prepare to contribute;
- the room learns that thinking time is normal;
- take +1 forward to Recursive Why or Probe.
- On a **7-9**, the silence yields something, but choose one:
 - you must narrow the question;
 - one student rescues the room too quickly;
 - attention wavers at the edges.
- On a **miss**, the silence becomes avoidance, confusion, or status anxiety.

Contradiction

When you introduce conflicting evidence, a counterexample, or an opposing viewpoint to create productive intellectual tension, roll +**Rigor**.

- On a **10+**, the contradiction opens genuine inquiry. Choose two:
 - students revise a claim;
 - students identify the source of tension;
 - the conflict deepens the concept rather than distracting from it;
 - take +1 forward to Source Interrogation or Threshold Concept.
- On a **7-9**, the contradiction works, but choose one:
 - students treat it as a trick;
 - the debate outruns the evidence;
 - you must stabilize the key concept before continuing.
- On a **miss**, the contradiction confuses, polarizes, or derails the lesson.

Recursive Why

When you repeatedly probe underlying assumptions by asking why, what follows, or what must be true, roll +**Rigor**.

- On a **10+**, the chain reaches a meaningful assumption. Choose two:
 - the student sees the root of their claim;
 - the class hears reasoning unfold;
 - a hidden misconception becomes teachable;
 - take +1 forward to Press for Precision.
- On a **7-9**, the chain reveals something, but choose one:
 - it stops at a partial assumption;

- the student needs a restatement;
- the class needs a summary to stay with you.
- On a **miss**, the questioning becomes circular, exhausting, or performative.

The Facilitator

Collaboration, discourse, collective cognition.

Passive Bonus

When a Facilitator move lands on a **10+**, peer participation density increases during the next collaborative task.

Signature Moves

Distributed Voice

When you intentionally widen participation across social groups, confidence levels, or areas of the room, roll **+Rapport**.

- On a **10+**, more students enter the conversation without tokenism. Choose two:
 - a quieter voice contributes meaningfully;
 - dominant voices remain engaged without controlling the floor;
 - the room hears a wider range of thinking;
 - take +1 forward to Consensus Build.
- On a **7-9**, participation broadens, but choose one:
 - the contribution needs support;
 - the move feels slightly forced;
 - you must rebalance talk again soon.
- On a **miss**, the attempt exposes status dynamics or makes a student feel singled out.

Consensus Build

When you guide students toward a synthesized shared understanding after multiple contributions, roll **+Rapport**.

- On a **10+**, the class can name what it now agrees on and what remains open. Choose two:
 - competing ideas are represented fairly;
 - the synthesis improves on individual answers;
 - students can use the shared statement in the next task;
 - take +1 forward to Reflective Circle or Exit Ticket.

- On a **7-9**, consensus forms, but choose one:
 - it is thinner than you want;
 - one important disagreement is smoothed over;
 - you must provide the final wording.
- On a **miss**, consensus becomes compliance, confusion, or premature closure.

Structured Collaboration

When you assign roles, norms, resources, and procedures so students can work together productively, roll +**Momentum**.

- On a **10+**, the structure supports the thinking rather than replacing it. Choose three:
 - roles are clear;
 - accountability is shared;
 - talk stays connected to the task;
 - you can monitor without constantly intervening.
- On a **7-9**, collaboration functions, but choose one:
 - one role is weak or performative;
 - some groups need a restart;
 - the structure slows the strongest groups.
- On a **miss**, the procedure becomes the task, or group dynamics overpower the learning goal.

Reflective Circle

When you have students articulate learning, process, or group dynamics aloud in a shared circle, roll +**Rapport**.

- On a **10+**, reflection becomes evidence and culture. Choose two:
 - students name a real learning shift;
 - students identify a process that helped or hindered;
 - the tone remains honest and safe;
 - take +1 forward to Goal Ladder or Consensus Build.
- On a **7-9**, reflection happens, but choose one:
 - responses are generic;
 - one comment needs careful framing;
 - time runs short before synthesis.
- On a **miss**, reflection becomes performance, complaint, silence, or drift.

The Coach

Feedback, iteration, mastery.

Passive Bonus

When a Coach move lands on a **10+**, students recover from mistakes faster during the next practice cycle.

Signature Moves

Live Correction

When you give immediate in-process feedback during performance or practice, roll +**Rapport**.

- On a **10+**, the correction improves the attempt without breaking momentum. Choose two:
 - the student knows exactly what to adjust;
 - the tone preserves effort;
 - the correction benefits nearby students;
 - take +1 forward to Targeted Drill.
- On a **7-9**, the correction helps, but choose one:
 - it interrupts flow;
 - the student needs a model;
 - the feedback is useful but not yet internalized.
- On a **miss**, the correction lands as criticism, overload, or noise.

Targeted Drill

When you assign precise practice aligned to an observed weakness, roll +**Diagnosis**.

- On a **10+**, the drill attacks the right gap. Choose two:
 - repetition stays purposeful;
 - students can tell what is improving;
 - the task is narrow without becoming mechanical;
 - take +1 forward to Guided Release.
- On a **7-9**, the drill helps, but choose one:
 - it needs more variety;
 - motivation dips;
 - the weakness is only partly isolated.

- On a **miss**, students practice the wrong thing, automate an error, or experience the drill as punishment.

Error Conference

When you analyze mistakes collaboratively with students, roll +**Rapport**.

- On a **10+**, the mistake becomes information. Choose two:
 - students can name the error pattern;
 - dignity is preserved;
 - the next attempt changes;
 - take +1 forward to Goal Ladder or Live Correction.
- On a **7-9**, the conference is useful, but choose one:
 - you must separate error from identity;
 - the student needs a smaller next step;
 - the discussion takes longer than expected.
- On a **miss**, the conference becomes defensiveness, shame, or over-explanation.

Goal Ladder

When you break long-term mastery into visible incremental targets, roll +**Clarity**.

- On a **10+**, students see a path from current ability to next mastery. Choose two:
 - the next rung is actionable;
 - progress can be recognized;
 - the ladder keeps rigor visible;
 - take +1 forward to Targeted Drill or Guided Release.
- On a **7-9**, the ladder helps, but choose one:
 - the target is measurable but not meaningful;
 - the next rung is too large;
 - students need examples of each level.
- On a **miss**, the ladder becomes a checklist, label, or ceiling.

The Performer

Energy, emotion, narrative, attention control.

Passive Bonus

When a Performer move lands on a **10+**, attention decay slows during the next explanation or discussion.

Signature Moves

Story Hook

When you introduce a concept through a dramatic narrative, scenario, puzzle, or human stakes, roll +**Presence**.

- On a **10+**, the hook creates attention that transfers to the concept. Choose two:
 - students want the answer;
 - the story points to the learning goal;
 - the emotional frame is memorable;
 - take +1 forward to Signal Importance or Direct Instruction.
- On a **7-9**, the hook catches attention, but choose one:
 - the story risks overshadowing the concept;
 - the transition into content needs care;
 - some students enjoy it without learning from it.
- On a **miss**, the hook distracts, confuses, or feels unrelated.

Dramatic Pause

When you manipulate silence and anticipation to heighten attention before a reveal, question, or key point, roll +**Presence**.

- On a **10+**, the pause sharpens focus. Choose two:
 - students lean into the next moment;
 - the key idea gains weight;
 - pacing feels intentional;
 - take +1 forward to Signal Importance.
- On a **7-9**, the pause works, but choose one:
 - it feels slightly theatrical;
 - timing is imperfect;
 - you need to recover momentum immediately afterward.
- On a **miss**, the pause reads as uncertainty, delay, or loss of thread.

Emotional Anchor

When you attach learning to a memorable emotional frame, value, dilemma, or lived significance, roll +**Presence**.

- On a **10+**, emotion supports memory and meaning. Choose two:
 - students can connect the feeling to the idea;
 - the frame respects the subject and the learners;
 - the lesson gains urgency without manipulation;
 - take +1 forward to Retrieval Practice or Reflective Circle.
- On a **7-9**, the anchor helps, but choose one:
 - it resonates with only part of the room;
 - it needs debriefing;
 - it makes the lesson more intense than planned.
- On a **miss**, the emotional frame overwhelms, trivializes, or misfires.

Presence Shift

When you alter voice, movement, pace, posture, or physical positioning to recapture attention, roll +**Presence**.

- On a **10+**, the shift resets attention without breaking the lesson. Choose two:
 - students notice the change;
 - the shift fits the moment;
 - momentum returns;
 - take +1 forward to Reset the Room or Signal Importance.
- On a **7-9**, attention improves, but choose one:
 - the shift must be followed by a clearer task;
 - it works briefly;
 - it draws attention to you more than the learning.
- On a **miss**, the shift feels performative, random, or ineffective.

The Scholar

Disciplinary rigor, nuance, conceptual depth.

Passive Bonus

When a Scholar move lands on a **10+**, students produce more precise disciplinary language during the next related task.

Signature Moves

Define the Term

When you introduce exact academic vocabulary, distinctions, or disciplinary language, roll **+Rigor**.

- On a **10+**, the term becomes a thinking tool. Choose two:
 - students can use it in context;
 - students can distinguish it from a near term;
 - the definition improves the work, not just the wording;
 - take +1 forward to Press for Precision.
- On a **7-9**, the term is introduced, but choose one:
 - students can repeat it before they can use it;
 - the distinction needs examples;
 - the word raises the cognitive load.
- On a **miss**, the term becomes jargon, ornament, or a barrier.

Trace the Idea

When you connect a concept across historical, disciplinary, textual, or practical contexts, roll **+Rigor**.

- On a **10+**, students see the concept travel. Choose two:
 - continuity is visible;
 - change across contexts is visible;
 - the connection deepens the current lesson;
 - take +1 forward to Threshold Concept or Retrieval Practice.
- On a **7-9**, the connection helps, but choose one:
 - one context receives too little explanation;
 - students see similarity but not difference;
 - the thread needs a summary.
- On a **miss**, the connection becomes a tangent or collapses important distinctions.

Source Interrogation

When you critically examine a source's origin, reliability, perspective, method, or purpose, roll +**Rigor**.

- On a **10+**, students treat the source as constructed evidence. Choose two:
 - they identify a relevant strength;
 - they identify a relevant limitation;
 - they connect source analysis to the claim at hand;
 - take +1 forward to Ask for Evidence or Contradiction.
- On a **7-9**, interrogation begins, but choose one:
 - students default to generic reliability language;
 - they critique the source without using it;
 - they need a model of disciplinary standards.
- On a **miss**, source analysis becomes cynicism, checklist work, or unsupported dismissal.

Threshold Concept

When you reveal a transformative conceptual insight that changes how students see the subject, roll +**Clarity**.

- On a **10+**, the threshold opens. Choose two:
 - students can name the before-and-after shift;
 - the insight reorganizes earlier knowledge;
 - students can apply it to a new example;
 - take +1 forward to Narrative Thread.
- On a **7-9**, the insight appears, but choose one:
 - some students glimpse it but cannot yet use it;
 - it needs a concrete example;
 - it unsettles prior understanding more than expected.
- On a **miss**, the concept becomes mystical, too abstract, or disconnected from practice.

The Warden

Culture, behaviour, routines, momentum.

Passive Bonus

When a Warden move lands on a **10+**, transition time decreases during the next classroom shift.

Signature Moves

Nonverbal Correction

When you redirect behaviour through proximity, gesture, eye contact, placement, or a silent cue without interrupting instruction, roll **+Presence**.

- On a **10+**, the correction works invisibly. Choose two:
 - instruction continues;
 - the student adjusts without embarrassment;
 - nearby students remain focused;
 - take +1 forward to Routine Lock or Positive Narration.
- On a **7-9**, the correction works, but choose one:
 - it must be repeated;
 - only the immediate behaviour changes;
 - you need a later private follow-up.
- On a **miss**, the cue is missed, misread, or escalates attention toward the behaviour.

Positive Narration

When you publicly name desired behaviour that is already happening, roll **+Presence**.

- On a **10+**, the narration spreads the routine without sounding artificial. Choose two:
 - students know exactly what to copy;
 - the named students retain dignity;
 - the class shifts toward the norm;
 - take +1 forward to Tighten Transition.
- On a **7-9**, the narration helps, but choose one:
 - it sounds slightly procedural;
 - the effect is temporary;
 - one group needs a different cue.
- On a **miss**, the narration feels manipulative, unnoticed, or unfair.

Routine Lock

When you automate a recurring classroom procedure until students can run it with minimal prompting, roll +**Momentum**.

- On a **10+**, the routine becomes classroom infrastructure. Choose three:
 - students know the sequence;
 - materials or roles are predictable;
 - the routine protects learning time;
 - you can use it under pressure.
- On a **7-9**, the routine works, but choose one:
 - it depends on your active monitoring;
 - it breaks with absences, novelty, or stress;
 - some students comply without understanding the purpose.
- On a **miss**, the routine becomes brittle, overcontrolled, or ignored.

Calm Reset

When you restore order without escalation after behaviour, noise, conflict, or confusion disrupts the lesson, roll +**Presence**.

- On a **10+**, order returns and dignity remains intact. Choose two:
 - the class can re-enter the task;
 - the tone lowers rather than sharpens;
 - the cause is contained or named;
 - take +1 forward to Reset the Room or Tighten Transition.
- On a **7-9**, order returns, but choose one:
 - the emotional residue remains;
 - you lose instructional time;
 - a follow-up conversation is required.
- On a **miss**, the reset escalates, suppresses without resolving, or leaves the room waiting for the next disruption.

Multi-Classing

Most real teachers are hybrids.

Hybrid	Style
Instructor + Coach	Explicit teaching with strong feedback loops
Socratic + Scholar	Rigorous academic dialogue
Facilitator + Performer	Highly engaging collaborative environment
Warden + Instructor	Extremely efficient classroom systems

When you multiclass, choose the move that matches what you are actually doing in the room, not the identity you prefer. The fiction decides the move.

Advancement System

Moves can upgrade when the teacher gains timing, room-reading, subject knowledge, and trust. An upgraded move is not just stronger. It has a sharper trigger, a clearer risk, and a more demanding success condition.

Cold Call Upgrades

Basic Cold Call

When you select a student and ask them to answer, roll +**Rapport**.

- On a **10+**, the student contributes and the room accepts the norm of shared participation.
- On a **7-9**, the student contributes, but choose one:
 - the answer needs support;
 - the call feels socially risky;
 - you learn less than you hoped.
- On a **miss**, the call feels like exposure, guessing, or compliance. Repair the participation norm.

Warm Cold Call

When you give think time, a prompt, or a rehearsal opportunity before selecting a student, roll +**Rapport**.

- On a **10+**, the student answers with preparation, and the class sees cold calling as thinking support rather than ambush. Take +1 forward to Bounce.
- On a **7-9**, preparation helps, but choose one:
 - the answer still needs scaffolding;
 - only some students used the think time;

- the routine needs more normalization.
- On a **miss**, the warmth is too thin: students experience the selection as sudden anyway.

Targeted Cold Call

When you select a student based on diagnostic need, observed readiness, or a misconception you want to surface, roll +**Diagnosis**.

- On a **10+**, the selection reveals exactly the evidence you need while preserving dignity. Choose two:
 - the student can attempt the answer;
 - the misconception becomes useful to the class;
 - you know the next instructional move;
 - take +1 forward to Precision Check.
- On a **7-9**, the call gives evidence, but choose one:
 - the student's readiness was misjudged;
 - the evidence is useful but socially delicate;
 - you must follow with a scaffold immediately.
- On a **miss**, the target was wrong or too exposed. The room makes a move.

Chain Cold Call

When you sequence responses across multiple students so each answer develops the previous one, roll +**Rapport**.

- On a **10+**, the chain builds collective reasoning. Choose three:
 - each student has a distinct role;
 - the thread remains coherent;
 - students listen because their turn may depend on it;
 - the final answer is stronger than the first.
- On a **7-9**, the chain works, but choose one:
 - one link repeats rather than extends;
 - a student needs a sentence stem;
 - you must summarize to preserve coherence.
- On a **miss**, the chain becomes a quiz line, public pressure, or fragmented talk.

Relay Cold Call

When you require students to build directly on previous answers by adding, qualifying, challenging, or evidencing, roll +**Rigor**.

- On a **10+**, the relay produces disciplined academic exchange. Choose two:
 - students reference one another accurately;
 - claims become more precise;
 - evidence or reasoning improves;
 - take +1 forward to Consensus Build.
- On a **7-9**, the relay advances, but choose one:
 - students need explicit talk moves;
 - the exchange narrows to confident speakers;
 - you must intervene to maintain standards.
- On a **miss**, students perform connection without listening, or the relay turns competitive.

Master-Level Moves

These moves require timing, room-reading, experience, and a willingness to let the lesson breathe without losing command of it.

Surf the Confusion

When you recognize productive uncertainty and resist rescuing students too early, roll +**Diagnosis**.

- On a **10+**, confusion becomes cognitive work. Choose two:
 - students struggle with the right problem;
 - frustration stays within tolerance;
 - a student-generated insight emerges;
 - take +1 forward to Threshold Concept or Consensus Build.
- On a **7-9**, the confusion is useful but unstable. Choose one:
 - offer a minimal hint;
 - narrow the task;
 - pause to name what kind of confusion this is.
- On a **miss**, you wait too long, rescue too soon, or misread confusion as productivity.

Invisible Scaffold

When you support struggling students without publicly lowering the task's rigor or marking them as deficient, roll +**Rapport**.

- On a **10+**, the support works and the standard remains intact. Choose two:
 - the student can re-enter the task;
 - peers do not read the support as a lower track;
 - the scaffold fades naturally;
 - take +1 forward to Guided Release.
- On a **7-9**, the scaffold helps, but choose one:
 - it is more visible than intended;
 - it supports access but not yet independence;
 - you must provide a parallel challenge elsewhere.
- On a **miss**, the support either exposes the student or quietly lowers the work too far.

Cognitive Pivot

When you redesign an explanation, task, representation, or sequence in real time based on emerging misunderstanding, roll +**Diagnosis**.

- On a **10+**, the pivot meets the misconception at its source. Choose three:
 - the new route is clearer;
 - students understand why the pivot is happening;
 - pacing remains recoverable;
 - the original learning goal survives.
- On a **7-9**, the pivot helps, but choose one:
 - you sacrifice planned depth;
 - you stabilize only part of the room;
 - you need to revise the next lesson.
- On a **miss**, the pivot becomes a detour, reveals a bigger gap, or creates a second confusion.

Narrative Thread

When you sustain conceptual coherence across a whole lesson, sequence, or unit so students can feel the learning arc, roll +**Clarity**.

- On a **10+**, the thread holds. Choose three:
 - students can explain where they have been;

- students know what question still drives the work;
- prior lessons become resources;
- the next lesson feels necessary.
- On a **7-9**, the thread is visible, but choose one:
 - you must restate the arc explicitly;
 - one lesson sits awkwardly in the sequence;
 - students remember activities more than ideas.
- On a **miss**, the unit becomes a series of tasks rather than an encounter with a concept.

The Deepest Insight

The reason this framework feels compelling is because teaching already behaves like a tactical improvisational system.

Expert teachers:

- monitor hidden states,
- anticipate failure conditions,
- deploy situational moves,
- manage pacing,
- and adapt in real time.

They are not merely delivering lessons.

They are running encounters.

Appendix I: Deep Research on 6 Teaching Stats

This report analyzes key professional teaching qualities—**Presence, Rigor, Momentum, Clarity, Rapport, and Diagnosis**—by defining each term, distinguishing how it manifests internally (in the teacher’s thinking and attitude) and externally (in classroom practice), and outlining developmental trajectories from novice to expert. *Presence* (often called teacher immediacy) is the teacher’s ability to command attention through confident body language, voice, and eye contact, reducing psychological distance with students 【42†L1-L4】. Novices should practice clear posture and engage tone, while masters naturally project focus and use gaze and prosody to align with students’ attention (even creating neural synchrony linked to learning) 【7†L69-L77】 【42†L1-L4】. *Rigor* means the teacher’s commitment to accuracy, evidence, and intellectual standards. Internally it involves traits like diligence, self-discipline, and willingness to question assumptions; externally it shows in challenging content, careful explanations, and

correction of errors. Novices can develop rigor by insisting on correct reasoning and evidence, while experts model epistemic responsibility, continually probing and justifying ideas.

Momentum refers to sustained drive and resilience in teaching. Inwardly it is a goal-directed mindset and self-regulation, and outwardly it appears as persistent pacing and calm recovery from setbacks. Novice teachers should build confidence and stamina (for example by planning well and maintaining a steady pace), whereas masterful teachers seem almost in a state of “flow,” maintaining focus and momentum seamlessly through disruptions 【41†L0-L4】. *Clarity* is the precision and coherence of thought and communication. Internally it stems from organized, focused thinking; externally it shows in structured lessons, clear explanations, and minimized cognitive load. Novices should work on breaking content into small steps, using examples and explicit signaling, while experts present even complex ideas in coherent, scaffolded ways that keep students tracking the “signal” rather than unnecessary “noise.” (Cognitive science notes that guided instruction with worked examples greatly benefits learners by reducing extraneous load 【26†L155-L162】.) *Rapport* is the quality of the emotional and social connection with students. Internally it reflects empathy, respect, and authenticity; externally it appears as trust, warmth, and mutual attentiveness. Novice teachers should learn students’ names, show genuine interest, and be consistently kind, while masters cultivate a safe, inclusive climate where learners feel understood and motivated. Research emphasizes that supportive teacher–student relationships (“positive connections”) lead students to feel “**safe, understood and appreciated**”, boosting engagement and achievement 【29†L144-L153】 【29†L198-L201】. Finally, *Diagnosis* is the ongoing process of interpreting student thinking and classroom dynamics. It involves an inquiring mindset (metacognition and humility) internally and adaptive responsiveness externally. Novices begin by using formative assessments and questioning to gather clues, whereas expert teachers continuously form and test hypotheses about underlying causes of confusion or behavior. Effective formative assessment – defined as a cyclical process of gathering evidence and adjusting instruction – can greatly improve learning; for example, research shows that providing accurate evidence and descriptive feedback significantly raises student achievement 【33†L101-L110】 【33†L146-L153】. Throughout, experts seamlessly integrate such diagnosis into teaching, reading the “system” of the classroom and intervening to guide learning. In the full report below, each section defines the term, cites relevant research, and details its classroom indicators, novice learning steps, and markers of mastery.

Presence

Summary: *Presence* (or teacher immediacy) is the teacher’s compelling sense of authority and engagement that draws students’ attention. Internally, a teacher with strong presence holds confidence, clarity of purpose, and intentional focus; externally, presence shows in open body

language, eye contact, and expressive vocal tone. Novice teachers can develop presence by practicing deliberate gestures, varying voice and movement to keep students attentive, and reducing formality to lower student anxiety 【42†L1-L4】 . By contrast, a masterful teacher exudes a natural presence: they command the room without dominating it, using mutual gaze and pacing to connect with learners. Indeed, research shows that such immediacy behaviors (like relaxed posture, nodding, smiling, and calling students by name) significantly boost student motivation and learning 【42†L1-L4】 . Cognitive neuroscience adds that physical cues of presence (especially eye contact) can align teacher and student brain activity, directly enhancing retention 【7†L69-L77】 . In practice, an expert maintains presence even under stress, ensuring that students feel both guided and engaged.

Researchers have long found that greater teacher immediacy correlates with better student outcomes 【12†L216-L224】 【42†L1-L4】 . For example, a classroom where the teacher makes eye contact, moves purposefully, and uses an expressive tone will feel more connected. A novice might start by greeting students warmly and making eye contact with different groups. A master cultivates *immediacy*: walking among students to close psychological distance, sharing enthusiasm for the content, and modulating pace and volume to keep attention high 【42†L1-L4】 【7†L69-L77】 .

- **Novice focus:** Practice nonverbal immediacy – smile, use open posture, make frequent eye contact, and speak with varied tone. Learn students’ names and refer to them.
- **Masterful behavior:** Naturally engage each student, using steady gaze and confident stance. Synchronize verbal explanations with gestures and prosody, so students remain mentally “tuned in” – brain studies confirm that teacher-student synchrony predicts learning gains 【7†L69-L77】 .

Rigor

Summary: *Rigor* is the teacher’s unwavering commitment to high standards of accuracy, evidence, and depth. Internally, rigor manifests as intellectual discipline: the teacher maintains a rigorous mindset of critical thinking, attention to detail, and respect for truth. Externally, it appears in challenging instruction, where tasks demand precision and the teacher insists on justification of answers. Novices should work on thoroughly understanding material themselves and always asking “Is this correct and why?”; experts demonstrate rigor by constantly questioning assumptions, pointing out nuances, and refusing to gloss over errors. A novice teacher might begin by double-checking all facts and correcting small mistakes when they occur. A masterful teacher goes further: they design lessons that push students to deep reasoning, immediately address misconceptions with evidence, and exemplify rigorous thinking (e.g. by explaining the rationale behind each step). In effect, the rigorous teacher treats

knowledge claims as hypotheses: they verify and justify them for learners. While direct research on “teaching rigor” is sparse, related work on *intellectual virtues* suggests that qualities like intellectual humility and perseverance underpin rigorous practice. For example, teachers who model self-questioning and a careful consideration of evidence (akin to scientific reasoning) help students learn not just facts but how to think critically.

- **Novice focus:** Know the content well and be willing to say “I’ll find out” when unsure. Check answers against evidence (e.g. textbook, data). Emphasize accuracy in grading and feedback.
- **Masterful behavior:** Pose challenging problems that require justification. Highlight exceptions or counterexamples, and require students to back up claims. Show that even complex ideas can be made precise by breaking them into clear, evidence-based arguments.

Momentum

Summary: *Momentum* refers to a teacher’s sustained forward-driving energy and pace. Inwardly, it means a resilient, goal-oriented mindset that keeps the teacher focused on instructional objectives despite obstacles. Outwardly, momentum is seen in the classroom as continual progress: lessons flow at a lively but controlled pace, and students perceive steady advancement toward learning goals. Novices should work on building confidence and persistence – for example, by planning well and setting small goals so they can “keep moving forward” even when difficulties arise. Experts, however, display effortless momentum: they are calm and decisive during complex lessons, and when disruptions occur they recover quickly. This often looks like being “in the zone” or *flow*: highly practiced teachers seem fully immersed and “in motion” even under pressure 【41†L0-L4】. Studies of expertise note that what appears as intuition is usually trained persistence and automaticity. For instance, experienced teachers can juggle explaining, monitoring, and redirecting simultaneously without losing stride. By contrast, a novice might falter after interruptions, whereas a master adjusts pacing on the fly – perhaps by summarizing quickly after a digression or by seamlessly transitioning to the next concept without dropping engagement. Maintaining momentum also involves emotional resilience: a strong teacher stays positive and patient after setbacks, encouraging students and persisting with the plan.

- **Novice focus:** Set clear lesson goals and keep lessons on a forward trajectory. If a question or activity stalls, have a backup plan or a brief summarizing statement to regain pace. Build stamina by practicing lessons and reflecting on what broke momentum.

- **Masterful behavior:** Exhibit confident continuity: even under challenge, the teacher maintains a productive tempo and sense of direction. In a master's classroom, transitions are smooth, discussions stay on track, and any loss of attention is swiftly recovered. The teacher's sustained focus resembles the *flow* state of full immersion 【41†L0-L4】 , ensuring students remain engaged and on-task throughout.

Clarity

Summary: *Clarity* is the precision and coherence of the teacher's thought and communication. Internally, a clear teacher organizes ideas tightly, eliminates ambiguity in their own understanding, and is fully focused on the point to be taught. Externally, clarity manifests as well-structured lessons: concepts are broken into manageable parts, explanations are concise and free of unnecessary jargon, and exemplars or analogies are used judiciously. Novices should work on thinking through their lessons in advance, using an explicit outline and simple language. As they teach, they should frequently check for understanding and rephrase points that seem confusing. Experts, by contrast, communicate complex content transparently: they choose examples that leverage students' prior knowledge, sequence topics in a logical build-up, and continuously signal what is important. Instructional research supports this: guided and explicit instruction – where teachers model procedures and provide worked examples – dramatically reduces cognitive load for learners 【26†L155-L162】 . In practice, a teacher with mastery of clarity might begin a lesson with an outline of goals, then proceed step-by-step, pausing to highlight connections or potential pitfalls. They avoid throwing too many new ideas at once, thus keeping extraneous mental load low.

- **Novice focus:** Plan carefully to isolate the next concept. Use brief, direct explanations and concrete examples. Explicitly define terms and check frequently that students are following (e.g. by asking a student to summarize).
- **Masterful behavior:** Craft explanations that naturally scaffold understanding. Use analogies and diagrams only to illuminate key ideas (not as filler). Continually monitor where students' thinking is, and re-explain immediately if needed. The classroom signals clarity: the teacher's talk is well-paced and purposeful, and students ask more “deeper” questions rather than asking for repeated explanations.

Rapport

Summary: *Rapport* is the emotional and relational quality of the classroom environment. Internally, it relies on the teacher's empathy, approachability, and respect for students as individuals. Externally, rapport is seen in trusting, supportive interactions: students feel psychologically safe, valued, and motivated to participate. Novices should build rapport by

learning students' names quickly, greeting them warmly, and showing genuine interest in their perspectives. Over time, they should use inclusive language (like “we” and “us”) and share appropriate personal anecdotes to humanize the teacher–student connection. Masterful teachers, however, create a stable culture of mutual respect and enthusiasm. They listen attentively to student concerns, adapt to students' cultural and personal backgrounds, and celebrate small successes, thus reinforcing a sense of belonging. Educational research underlines the impact: classrooms where students feel “**safe, understood and appreciated**” foster stronger learning relationships 【29†L144-L153】. In such classes, teachers maintain high expectations paired with trust and consistency, which in turn builds students' confidence. Studies have found that when teacher–student connections are positive and respectful, students show better attitudes, higher achievement, and greater school engagement 【29†L198-L201】.

- **Novice focus:** Greet each student warmly, use their names, and learn about their interests. Be fair and consistent in discipline. Show patience and understanding when students make mistakes.
- **Masterful behavior:** Intentionally foster a classroom culture of care and respect. Build trust gradually through reliable routines and positive feedback. Encourage student voices and gently challenge disrespect. In an expert-led class, students volunteer thoughts eagerly, help each other, and students know the teacher values their contributions.

Diagnosis

Summary: *Diagnosis* is the continuous process of interpreting students' thinking and classroom dynamics to guide instruction. Internally, it is a reflective, investigative mindset: the teacher constantly analyzes cues (like questions, errors, and engagement levels) and forms hypotheses about student understanding. Externally, diagnosis appears as adaptive teaching: prompt adjustments to explanations or activities based on assessment data and observation. Novice teachers often start by using simple diagnostics – asking cold-call questions, giving quick quizzes, or looking for hand-raising – to get feedback. They learn to listen closely and notice when faces look puzzled or bored. Expert teachers, however, integrate diagnosis seamlessly. They implement formative assessments as part of every lesson (such as exit tickets or concept checks) and then immediately tailor subsequent steps. For example, an expert might recognize a common misconception from student answers and then reframe the next problem to address it. Foundational research on formative assessment shows that when teachers gather accurate evidence of understanding and give descriptive (not just evaluative) feedback, student learning improves markedly 【33†L101-L110】 【33†L146-L153】. In fact, Black and William (1998) identified that the key to large achievement gains is precisely this cycle of evidence and

responsive feedback. Ultimately, proficient diagnostic teachers treat each classroom event not as isolated, but as data: they are part instructor, part scientist.

- **Novice focus:** Use simple checks for understanding: ask students to paraphrase a point or use thumbs-up/down during class. After an activity, scan student work for common errors. If many students struggle, be ready to reteach a concept.
- **Masterful behavior:** Systematically integrate formative practices. Clearly communicate learning targets and provide exemplars of good work. Continuously monitor progress (through quizzes, observations, or even body language) and ask: “What is causing this confusion?” Then adjust: break tasks differently, offer hints, or move on as appropriate. In a master’s classroom, lessons are fluid – for instance, the teacher might extend an explanation on the spot when noticing hesitation, or switch to a collaborative exercise if individual work falters. Such teachers are comfortable with uncertainty; they deliberately slow down or add challenge based on ongoing evidence, ensuring that no student’s misunderstanding is left unchecked.

Sources: Each section above is grounded in educational research and theory. For example, studies of teacher immediacy and presence show that nonverbal behaviors like eye contact and movement boost motivation 【42†L1-L4】 , while recent neuroscience links teacher–student brain synchrony with learning outcomes 【7†L69-L77】 . Cognitive science underlines the importance of reducing extraneous cognitive load through clear, structured instruction 【26†L155-L162】 . Research on relationships highlights that students learn best when they feel supported and valued 【29†L144-L153】 【29†L198-L201】 . And extensive formative assessment literature emphasizes that diagnostic, feedback-driven teaching significantly enhances achievement 【33†L101-L110】 【33†L146-L153】 . The discussion above weaves these insights into practical implications for teachers at different stages of expertise, from novice to master.